Codestable

Executive Summary: Codestable

Problem

Many retirees want to earn some extra money or keep their minds active after leaving their careers. Fixed incomes do not always stretch as far as people expect, and a lot of retirees say they feel bored or disconnected once they stop working. At the same time, there is a large amount of freelance work available online, including website updates, spreadsheet cleanup and simple automation. Most retirees who worked in fields like teaching, nursing, retail or office administration do not have the technical background to do this kind of work. Existing coding courses are mostly built for students and career changers in their twenties and thirties. They move quickly, use a lot of jargon and assume the learner is comfortable with technology. Retirees who try them often give up. We think this is a real problem for a growing group of people, and we want to help.

Solution

Codestable is an app that teaches basic programming through short guided puzzles. Each puzzle takes about five to ten minutes and teaches one small idea, such as how a list works or how to repeat an action. The app gives hints at each step and explains mistakes in plain language rather than technical terms. Users move through levels, and as they progress the puzzles start to look more like real freelance tasks, for example fixing a broken web page or sorting a spreadsheet. The idea is that a retiree can start with no experience and, after a few months of regular use, have enough skill to take small paid jobs. We chose short puzzles because we believe older learners prefer manageable sessions that fit into a daily routine and give a quick feeling of success.

Market

There are over fifty million Americans aged sixty-five and older, and the number is growing every year as the population ages. Many of them are comfortable using smartphones and tablets. If even a small share of these people were interested in learning to code for part-time income, the market would be very large. We estimate that if just two percent of retirees subscribed to a product like ours, that would be a significant business. The freelance economy is also growing, and more companies are comfortable hiring remote workers for small tasks. We believe these trends together create a good opportunity for Codestable. Our initial focus will be retirees in our region, who we can reach through community centers, libraries and senior programs, before expanding nationally.

Business Model

Codestable will charge a monthly subscription. We are currently thinking of a price of around twelve dollars per month, with a free trial period so people can try the app before paying. We may also offer a discounted yearly plan. In the future we could add other revenue sources, such as connecting graduates with freelance job platforms and taking a small fee, or partnering with senior centers and retirement communities that could offer Codestable to their members as a benefit. We have not yet tested these ideas, and we are still working out the right pricing and how to bring in users at a low cost. Our main goal right now is to prove that retirees will use the product regularly and find it valuable.

Competition

There are many coding education products on the market, including large online course platforms and several popular apps for learning to program. These products are well funded and have many users. However, they are generally designed for younger people and do not focus on retirees or on freelance income. Codestable is different because it is built specifically for older adults from non-technical backgrounds, with a slower pace, plainer language and a goal of helping users earn money. We think this focus gives us an advantage, although we recognize that a

larger company could add similar features if they decided to target this group. We also compete with free tutorials and videos that retirees could find on their own.

Team

Marcus Delacroix-Whitfield is a senior studying computer science at our university and built the first prototype of the app. Priya Ramanathan-Ortiz is a junior studying business and is responsible for user research and outreach. She spent a summer volunteering at a community center, which gave her the idea for the project. Tobias Kellner is a junior studying education and is designing the puzzle content and lesson structure. Together we cover technology, business and teaching. None of us has run a company before, but we have worked well together on class projects and are committed to the venture.

Milestones and Financials

So far we have defined our core concept, built a working prototype with an initial set of about forty puzzles, and registered Codestable as an LLC. We also have a website that explains the product. Recently we gave the prototype to our first external users, a small group of retirees from a local community center, and early feedback has been encouraging. Several users said they enjoyed the puzzles and wanted more. We have not yet charged anyone, so we have no revenue. Our costs so far have been small and paid by the founders, mainly for legal registration and website hosting. Over the next year we expect to spend money on app development, more puzzle content, and marketing. If things go well, we hope to begin charging subscribers within about nine months and reach a few thousand users in the first two years, though these numbers are rough estimates.

What We Are Asking For

We are applying to this competition to win funding and gain mentorship. We would use prize money to hire a part-time developer, expand our puzzle library and run a larger pilot with more retirees. We would also like advice from experienced entrepreneurs on pricing, how to reach our customers affordably, and how to turn Codestable into a sustainable business. Feedback from judges would be very valuable to us. We believe Codestable can help retirees learn new skills and earn extra income, and we are excited to keep building it.